Q. If President Trump seeks direct talks with Iran without preconditions, are you ready?
Right now we cannot make that decision. The same side that martyred our leader wants to talk to us directly. Our people are deeply concerned and this catastrophe that has been brought upon us will not be erased from their memory. We have to be sure if they will stand by and proceed within the same framework.

Q. What's Iran's reaction to the Makkah Pact amongst Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkey, with attacks by the Houthis alongside [Iran's] tensions with Saudi Arabia?
We are not at war with Saudi Arabia and the Houthis have their own issues. Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Pakistan and all regional countries must sit together and establish regional peace and security. Each can maintain its own interests and identity, but within a shared framework of security, while building a shared economy.

Q. Iran is retaliating against the US by attacking Gulf states. Isn't it what the West wants: to keep you divided?
Right now there are various ethnicities in Iran, and they want to pit them against each other. The same happens in neighbouring countries. Their intention is to pit Arab countries against Iran, so that we fight among ourselves and then they exploit our oil and sell weapons to the Arab countries while we keep fighting. From the start, I have tried to preserve unity and consistency in Iran, to turn differences of opinion into unity rather than discord.

Q. Why doesn't Iran reach out to the Arab world, breaking the Shia-Sunni divide that the West has exploited?
We have done this before. But the problem is the US has set up military bases in these countries, from where they attack us. We simply defend ourselves. While doing so, which place should we target? The same place from where their aircraft launched against our country. Naturally, this has caused friction. Do you expect us to do nothing?

Q. The result is a blockade of the Strait of Hormuz. India certainly is feeling the heat. What's the status of the Strait of Hormuz? Has the war expanded to the Bab-el-Mandeb Strait with the help of the Houthis, Hezbollah and Hamas?
Neither Hezbollah nor we initiated that. The enemy is attacking, and all these groups are defending themselves. Why are the Americans attacking our region, blocking our routes, and expecting us to do nothing? If we are alive, we have to respond. If the US wants to wage war, they should do it against military personnel—why are they doing it against civilians through sanctions and causing poverty, discontent and other problems? Maritime routes are easier, but not the only route. If they block them, we will not surrender.



IANS

"THANK GOD OUR SUPREME LEADER IS ALIVE. NATURALLY, HE HAS THE FINAL SAY. IT HAS BEEN THIS WAY FROM THE FIRST DAY, AND IT REMAINS THE SAME NOW"

Q. Have you given assurances to the Indian PM about the security of Indian vessels and seafarers in Hormuz Strait?
We are negotiating with Oman on a specific maritime framework. The foreign ministers of the Arab countries will meet with Oman to reach an agreement. Within internationally established principles, the waterway would be reopened, on condition that the US ends its blockade.

Q. How do you respond to the West's accusation that Russia and China support Iran militarily, strategically and technologically?
We have friendly relations with Russia and China, just as we'd like to expand relations with your country. And then we are accused of exchanging intelligence. The US, Israelis and the Europeans have technology and do whatever they want. They cannot even imagine that it was our people who stood against the great power—not technology. Since they cannot defeat us, they assume we are being supported from outside.

Q. How has your new Supreme Leader been? There has been so much speculation and intrigue.
Thank God, our Supreme Leader is alive and continues his work sincerely. Since they can't locate him precisely, they spread these speculations, hoping to do the same to him as well. Israel and America are the real terrorists. Look at what they are doing in Syria, Lebanon, Gaza, Iraq, and Qatar, and even in Iran—they assassinate anyone they wish, then claim these people were terrorists. They target bridges and factories; are those terrorists too?

Q. Where do negotiations stand on the transition of authority in Iran? Who takes the final call—the Ayatollah, IRGC, or you?
Naturally, it is the Supreme Leader who has the final say. It has been this way from the first day, and it remains the same now. ■